5/Recognizing Various Kinds of Excellence

In *The University in Ruins,* the literary scholar Bill Readings remarks that "the idea of excellence" is ubiquitously evoked in academic contexts, yet little consensus exists concerning its meaning. As a term, it "has the singular advantage of being entirely meaningless, or to put it more precisely, non-referential."[1] As panelists are very much aware, excellence is a quintessential polymorphic term. A sociologist notes, "There are different standards of excellence, different kinds of excellence," yet is nevertheless "pretty confident that I'd know it when I see it." This chapter spells out what this "it" is that panelists easily recognize but cannot always clearly articulate. As we will see, understanding the various meanings that reviewers attach to the evaluative criteria they use is at least as important as identifying the criteria themselves. In addition, the weight given to criteria—favoring intellectual significance over social significance, for instance—imponderably affects the outcome of deliberations and may have to do with differences in "intellectual habitus" across disciplinary clusters.[2]

In their classic work *The Academic Revolution,* Christopher Jencks and David Riesman observed that in the modern university, "claims of localism, sectarianism, ethnic prejudice and preference, class background, age, sex, and even occupational plans are largely ignored."[3] This remains the official credo of American higher education. The only sectarianism that is deemed acceptable is that of "high quality scholarship"—and it is in this context that particularistic considerations gain a footing. This is why it is crucial to look closely at how excellence is coded, signaled, and recognized.

In this chapter, I draw on the concept of "scripts" to analyze the meanings and relative importance panelists assign to the criteria they use to evaluate excellence." Borrowing from the sociologist Erving Goffman's concept of script, we can posit that individuals do not invent their standards of excellence anew. They draw on their environment and use shared conventions to make sense of their world.[4] To show how panel members go about making sense of their role in the world of evaluation, I begin by discussing the evidence on which they base their judgments: the proposal, the applicant, and the letters of recommendation. As we will see, these types of evidence receive different weight; the proposal, for example, counts much more than the letters. Next, I turn to how panelists interpret the formal categories that funding agencies ask them to consider. Again, the literature on peer review has focused on the weighting of evaluative criteria, leaving unexplored the meanings that evaluators assign to the criteria they use to assess excellence.[5] Here, I analyze responses provided by panelists during post-deliberation interviews to gain a better understanding of such meanings. I start by discussing clarity and "quality," the latter being shorthand for craftsmanship, depth, and thoroughness. I then turn to the more substantive criteria of originality, significance (scholarly and social/political), "methods" (which includes the articulation between theory, method, and data, and the proper use of theory), and feasibility (the applicant's readiness and track record, and the plan of work). Finally, I address the more evanescent qualities that are valued by panelists, most of which pertain more to the applicant than to the project. These evanescent qualities include which proposals and applicants generate "excitement" and which are "elegant" and "intelligent." Informal standards also include the proper display of "cultural capital" and perceptions of the moral quality of the applicant, particularly in relation to the authenticity of her intellectual commitment.

For seasoned evaluators, the ground covered in this chapter will be familiar; for more junior scholars and others still attempting to find the magic formula for winning fellowships, the discussion will provide a (sometimes surprising) picture of what defines a good proposal. We will see not only how frequently panelists mention the formal and informal criteria just noted, and which criteria they weight most heavily, but also the breadth of meanings attached to specific criteria. In the case of originality, for instance, the range of meanings used by panelists is much wider than has been posited by the positivist tradition. And with respect to evanescent qualities, we will see that more than half of the panelists accord these criteria sizable significance. I argue that moral considerations and class signals (namely, "elegance" and "cultural capital"), although they are somewhat antithetical to a merit-based award system, are intrinsic to the process of evaluation in academia.

Elements of the Proposal

As we saw in Chapter 2, the evidence on which screeners and panelists base their judgments normally includes information concerning the research project (project description, including bibliography and timetable), information about the applicant (biographical sketch, personal statement, curriculum vitae, publications/portfolio, grade transcript, teaching experience and interest, and statement of commitment to the goals of the program), supporting material (letters of recommendation), and, for the panelists, comments and a ranking assigned by the screeners.

Panelists understand proposals as part of a genre—as having certain recognizable characteristics and following certain known conventions, all of which give evaluators a basis for comparison and a common language for discussion. An anthropologist alludes to an element of this established genre when he remarks, "The first paragraph [should] make it clear what's going on . . . [we're] reading a twenty-page grant proposal in five minutes." And an English professor underscores the convention of discussing the "significance of [the] project, to convey a certain importance or excitement about the project [even if it is] a study of Greek coins from the second century BC. Why this is something that's worth doing, whether it's because it'll change the way we think about money or because it will tell us something about Greek society at this particular time, or simply because it'll tell you something about these objects that's new and interesting." Proposals that do not adhere to such conventions are doomed, despite any intrinsic interest they might have.

Yet some conventions also generate skepticism, because "anyone who's ever written [a proposal] knows that you [have to] sound convincing even about things you're not sure about." Thus panelists understand that proposal writing requires a certain amount of "impression management" or "bullshit."[6] A convincing proposal does not guarantee that the applicant really knows what he or she will be doing. But such limitations are construed as unavoidable in an imperfect and sometimes opaque system in which all parties have limited control. As we will see, many panelists believe that the authenticity of an applicant's intellectual engagement shines through in a proposal—and in fact they may impose what they call a "bullshit penalty" on proposals that seem shallow and formulaic. This is why proposals describing projects that are well advanced often are selected for funding, even when such decisions are at odds with a funding program's explicit objectives (such as to support fieldwork).

Advanced projects strike reviewers as almost "always better" because they are more specific, complete, and "elegant." Here the "bullshit penalty" does not necessarily apply because, in the words of one evaluator, "What difference does it make at what point the person gets the money? It's a reward for doing the work." Thus panelists, as well as applicants, appear to understand the rules of the game as being somewhat fluid and fuzzy.

Competition guidelines (described in Chapter 2) often emphasize that evaluators should focus on the strengths of the proposal, as opposed to the past record of the applicant. This is in line with funding agencies' commitment to a merit-based ethos. An economist feels that "it's unfair to those that spent a lot of time on those [proposals] to give . . . preference to someone's record." An English professor also makes the case for focusing on the proposal because "it is not always the case that [people who have the best track record] have put together the best proposals." Whether the competition supports graduate students or senior professors influences how much weight is put on track record or, alternatively, on likely future trajectory (measured in terms of promise and/or projected mobility). In either case, funding agencies do require consideration of the applicant in the assessment of merit. A standard question posed to panelists is, "Is this person well equipped to complete the project that is proposed?" Letters of support written by advisers and other supporters answer this question, but they address issues well beyond technical competence and preparation. Letters signal cultural capital, elegance, and other class-based evanescent qualities. The influence of letters is limited, however: a surprisingly large number of panelists (twenty-five of seventy-one) say that they pay little or no attention to letters, mainly because they are so often formulaic, hyperbolic, or uninformative.[7] As a historian puts it, "We had so many superlatives that, sometimes, it's hard to know how to interpret them."

Against this skepticism, panelists develop distinctive schemas to assess the value of letters, taking more seriously those that "conveyed a sense of excitement about the project," which can be produced only if the letter writer has immersed herself in the work. "All of the others, 'This is the best person in his or her field,' and of course, 'this is crucial and should be funded,' blah, blah, blah . . . They are assembly-line letters," an anthropologist says dismissively. "You know, everybody was 'the best in the field,' everybody was doing something that was 'the most important research.'" Similarly, a philosopher counterintuitively declares, "The more terms of praise I see in a letter, the less attention I gave to it. The more description I see, the more attention. If you just say 'it's great,' you're just passing the buck, in a way. We can't tell if it's great without knowing it, and knowing it is itself a sign of admiration . . . I see it myself, people I admire, I write about their projects. When I need to throw something off, I write 'Great! Brilliant!'" For an economist, "It's the specificity that matters . . . about what a student has done and how specific skills will influence a research topic." But if the applicant is unable to make a convincing case, no letter will tip the balance. It is the combination of strong letters and a great proposal that creates the conditions for building a consensus on quality, or even on "hotness" in fields that are more subject to bandwagon effects.[8]

The letters that count most are of two types. Those that explain a project's importance in specific terms and locate it in the literature can be, as one historian explains, "very, very helpful if they help someone like me who might not be particularly well read in a field to understand precisely why we should be interested." Similarly, those written by individuals whom panelists know personally or through their work can be very persuasive (see Chapter 3). An English scholar's explanation of why he particularly values a colleague's opinion illustrates how such a letter can influence one's judgment:

> Diane Middlebrook is somebody I know, not real well, but we have a lot of mutual friends. I've read her work, I've read other

letters of hers. I trust [them] and her intellect. She's not going to pump a candidate up, and she's also not going to deflate a candidate because they have some kind of [conflict] . . . She's somebody who has intellectual integrity.[9]

Similarly, a philosopher says that he assigned significant weight to a letter by the Nobel Prize–winning economist Amartya Sen because "He knows how to judge brilliance. He's had a lot of very brilliant people around him in his life." The same is said about another Nobel laureate, the Berkeley economist George Akerloff. To the extent that applicants located in more prestigious universities have greater access to well-known and well-connected letter writers, these applicants will likely be advantaged by those evaluators who put considerable weight on letters.[10]

Some panelists believe that letters are important in their "signaling" role, independent of their specific content.[11] Indeed, letters convey prestige, or a measure of quality, by association—the famous halo effect.[12] As one political scientist says, "I make judgments based on my knowledge of how distinguished the writer is, but I pay very little attention to what the writer actually says, because it's very hard to discriminate among the letters." The signaling effect of letters can be so strong as to override other factors. A philosopher provided this cautionary tale about a graduate student in his department: "We had to write his dissertation for him, but the description I had given on it was so good, he had twelve interviews. No one looked at him again after the interview. Since then, I've tried to be careful [to better align the letter with the accomplishments]." One political scientist says that because she "wants a clean sense of things," she makes up her mind solely on the basis of the proposal. She uses letters to revise her evaluation or as supporting evidence. Another panelist avoids reading the names of the letter writers until he has read the entire dossier, so as to equalize the playing field.

Six Criteria for Recognizing Excellence

Chapter 2 described the formal criteria that funding agencies ask panelists to consider in making awards (see especially Table 2.1). Chapter 3 provided a general analysis of disciplinary peculiarities with respect to what constitutes excellence. Here, I identify trends in panelists' understanding and use of evaluative criteria by regrouping these disciplines into the standard categories of humanities and social sciences, but I continue to treat history as its own category, standing between the humanities and social sciences. Table 5.1 shows the relative salience of formal criteria (defined as the number of times that respondents mention using each) across these disciplinary clusters.

The six criteria do not each receive the same weight. Originality, for example, is more heavily weighted than is feasibility (see Table 5.1.) Conflicts emerge over how much weight should be given to each criterion—to rigor versus innovation, for instance. One historian describes how he supported a proposal on what seemed to be a "cool idea": "My attraction to it was that I just could see the book, you know, and I was thinking this would be a really excellent, readable, teachable book, around a compelling idea . . . [It would] produce a kind of quality different than the usual more kind of massaged and theoretically sophisticated and careerist [project]. You know, I mean, it was something outside." An economist, who puts much more emphasis on methods and rigor, strongly opposed this proposal, despite its innovative character. Thus different standards are applied to the same proposals. Moreover, proposals do not win or lose for the same reasons. The social sciences and the humanities make up a multifaceted academic world; there is no single, integrated disciplinary hierarchy. Different pieces of scholarship shine under different lights. Many cross-cutting scholarly approaches partly reinforce one another, but also sometimes cancel one another

Table 5.1 Number of panelists mentioning each criterion, by disciplinary cluster

Criterion	*Humanities (N = 22)*	*History (N = 20)*	*Social sciences (N = 29)*	*Total (N = 71)*
Clarity	15 (68%)	16 (80%)	12 (41%)	43 (61%)
"Quality"	9 (41%)	8 (40%)	15 (52%)	32 (45%)
Originality	18 (82%)	19 (95%)	26 (90%)	63 (89%)
Significance	19 (86%)	19 (95%)	27 (93%)	65 (92%)
Methods	9 (41%)	11 (55%)	21 (72%)	41 (58%)
Feasibility	10 (45%)	11 (55%)	15 (52%)	36 (51%)

Note: A "mention" occurs when a criterion is used during the interview.

out. One anthropologist directly connects the valuing of a wide range of topics and types of scholarship with different standards of excellence. She traces this connection to the emergence of feminism in academia, and to the awareness of how power relationships shape criteria. "[There is] more than one model of excellence," she asserts. This view will be confirmed throughout this chapter, as we examine the main criteria of evaluation, starting with clarity and "quality."

Clarity and "Quality"

Only the ACLS, WWNFF, and SSRC specify clarity as a formal criterion of evaluation, but it is often the first characteristic that panelists mention when describing how they separate the wheat from the chaff. Although clarity is of greater importance to historians and humanists than to social scientists, in the aggregate, 61 percent of panelists who were asked to name their most important criteria for measuring excellence mentioned clarity, defining it in terms as varied as luminescence, transparency, precision, analytical articulation, crispness, and tightness (see Table 5.1.) That it is not explicitly mentioned by more reviewers indicates how taken-for-granted it is as a sine qua non for excellence. Particularly with respect to the proposal, form is as important as substance: it is a prerequisite for running the race. This is in part because of the time constraints typically faced by panelists as they make their way through a pile of applications. Panelists "are paid very little," a musicologist notes. "They're given a mountain of material, which they have to plow through and assess . . . What they principally do is deselect . . . as opposed to looking for ones that they really want to fund. So if you write poorly or you simply write in such a way that bores people, you're not likely . . . to surface." Similarly, a political scientist says, "The best proposals are the ones I didn't have to work at."

For many panelists, a clear writing style is a manifestation of a clear and orderly intellect. "The quality of writing says something about the clarity of the mind," an English professor remarks, adding, "To me, it is more important than whether the proposal is completely precise." Another English professor sees "a prose style that can handle complex ideas in a clear fashion" as indicating a sharp intelligence. Clarity is also taken to reveal competence ("It was written with a kind of clarity that made me feel that a person knows what they're talking about") and how much care applicants put into their proposals. This is because luminescence, transparency, precision, analytical articulation, and "crisp, tight, taut sentences" can be achieved only through the repeated polishing of successive drafts. Thus, a clear proposal, according to one English professor, "makes me feel confident that they will write a good book . . . if it's not carefully written, it makes me worry about thoughtfulness . . . the depth of thinking."

"Quality," like "excellence," is a catch-all referent that panelists persistently mobilize. Mentioned by 45 percent of the respondents, quality manifests itself through "craftsmanship," "depth," "attention to details," and "soundness." These in turn are associated with "rigor" and "solidity," with all of the terms used interchangeably to designate applicants who invest extra effort in creating their proposals.

Craftsmanship is admired by a sociologist who, when asked if he believes in academic excellence, answers, "If what we mean by excellence is honest work, well-crafted work, pretty much scholarship as craft, I believe in it." Elaborating, he stresses "work that's true to the data." He associates excellence "with [producing] work that is based upon good quality scholarship . . . *It is ethics, plus the craft* [my emphasis]." Similarly, a political scientist who "cares very much about the finished product" cautions that "to be a craftsman without insight or creativity, you know, that wouldn't work to create good objects. You have to be creative as well." Depth, another aspect of quality, is the dimension that humanists tend to stress most. A historian of China's description of a high-quality proposal reflects this concern: "There was a lot of historical work going into this one . . . but also depth. The statement had nuance in it. It was authoritatively written. You felt that this guy was full of respect and engagement and at the same time, had a certain kind of distance that would allow him to do really high-quality studies." Prevailing definitions of quality also frequently include praise for attention to detail. Thus a sociologist emphasizes thoroughness and describes his own work as being particularly strong on "rigorous historical analysis, which means not just sticking to the secondary sources, but also going to the primary sources." A historian emphasizes the applicant's thorough deliberation of research choices.

Finally, in defining quality, many respondents emphasize scholarly and empirical soundness. For the humanists, scholarly soundness is measured by the details and accuracy of the proposal. Thus, proposals that include factual errors are eliminated promptly. A historian recalled a losing proposal that was "riddled with historical anachronisms, historical assumptions that were just wrong, and yet [the applicant] used buzz words that were sort of trendy and would attract interest. It was kind of disingenuous." Empirical soundness is defined in opposition to the use of anecdotes and to what a music scholar describes as "spouting opinion." It is also frequently contrasted with the haphazard collection of evidence and with superficial "trendiness." A sociologist compares losers and winners this way:

> This one proposal on eighteenth-century Romanian national history was highly scholarly, absolutely in [the] forefront of debates on nationalism. It was empirically sound in particular research lights. And it seemed very detailed and he got the money because the Good Lord lives in details . . . Some of the trendy ones [that were not funded] were so much concerned with concepts . . . They were more about how we address certain things rather than actually the things themselves.

A political scientist concurs, describing scholarship she likes as work that "brings a lot of evidence to their arguments . . . I like Adam Przeworski's work, although it, like mine, takes a different form. I like projects where the author has really gone to a lot of trouble to legitimate what they said. And they can do that with case studies or through large and quantitative studies." In teaching her graduate students how to produce high-quality research, she directs them "to look at their variables very critically," "to look carefully at feasibility," to marshal "lots of evidence," and to bring many "different kinds of lenses" to their research problem.

Originality, Significance, Methods, and Feasibility

In discussing what defines the substantive quality of a project, respondents from all three disciplinary clusters seem to draw on shared "scripts" of excellence—sets of definitions and decision pathways in which originality and significance play a central role, with methods and feasibility also in crucial, but less widely agreed-on, positions. No clear patterns differentiate humanists, social scientists, and historians in how much importance they attach to any of these four criteria. As shown in Table 5.1, originality is mentioned at least once by 89 percent of the panelists, significance by 92 percent, methods (meaning theory, data, method, and the articulation of the three) by 58 percent, and feasibility by 51 percent.

Many forms of originality. The canonical sociological literature on the place of originality in scientific evaluation has defined originality, following Robert K. Merton, as the making of a new discovery that adds to scientific knowledge. Merton asserted that "it is through originality, in greater or smaller increments, that knowledge advances."[13] Thomas Kuhn expanded this understanding of originality by pointing out distinctions in how novel theories are received. Characterizing scientific communities as generally resistant to paradigmatic shifts, Kuhn argued that new discoveries confirming the theories of "normal science" are the mainstay of the scientific endeavor, while anomalous discoveries and consensus-challenging theories are seldom welcomed, and usually ignored.

Numerous scholars have built on this literature, and others have examined various aspects of the peer review process. No one, however, has yet questioned the specific assumption that originality consists of making new discoveries or producing new theories. For instance, although Bruno Latour and others have criticized the literature's emphasis on priority disputes, how academics define and go about assessing originality remains unexamined.[14] And although the canonical definition of originality arose from studies of the natural sciences and was not—at least not explicitly—intended to apply more broadly, it often is applied to the social sciences. The extent to which this definition characterizes the understanding of originality in the social sciences or humanities is still an open question.

Elsewhere, my colleagues Joshua Guetzkow, Grégoire Mallard, and I analyzed the way the panelists describe originality and found that their descriptions point toward a much broader definition than that posited in the literature.[15] We constructed a typology to classify the panelists' definitions. These categories of originality, shown in Table 5.2, include using a new approach, theory, method, or data (for example, original research is seen as "bringing a fresh perspective" or "drawing on new sources of information"); and studying a new topic, doing research in an understudied area, or producing new findings (such as when the researcher ventures "outside canonized authors"). We found differences by disciplinary cluster. Humanists and historians tend to define originality differently than do social scientists: they clearly privilege originality in approach, with humanists also emphasizing originality in the data used—with the uncovering of new texts and authors given special prominence (see Table 5.3). Social scientists most often mention originality in method, but they also seem to appreciate a more diverse range of types of originality, stressing the use of an original approach or theory, or the study of an original topic. Overall, this diversity strongly confirms the need for a more multidimensional definition of originality, at least as far as the humanities and social sciences are concerned.

Scholarly and political or social significance. Four of the five funding agencies I studied specified significance as a formal criterion of selection. Yet most funding institutions allow some ambiguity in how the term is defined. Here, following the lead of the panel members, I distinguish between scholarly (intellectual or theoretical) significance and social or political significance. Scholarly significance is determined on the basis of whether a project is likely to produce generalizable results and/or speak to broad theoretical questions or processes, as opposed to addressing narrowly defined or highly abstract topics. A project with social or political significance is believed to give voice to subordinate groups or produce socially useful knowledge. Further distinctions include those between the significance of a

Table 5.2 Frequencies of mentions of generic and specific types of originality

	Generic types (*N* = 217)													
	Original approach	*Freq. (%)*	*Understudied area*	*Freq. (%)*	*Original topic*	*Freq. (%)*	*Original theory*	*Freq. (%)*	*Original method*	*Freq. (%)*	*Original data*	*Freq. (%)*	*Original results*	*Freq. (%)*
Specific types	New approach	5 (7)	Understudied region	7 (54)	New topic	9 (28)	New theory	5 (13)	Innovative method or research design	5 (19)	New data	15 (52)	New insights	5 (56)
	New question	21 (31)	Understudied period	6 (46)	Non-canonical topic	20 (63)	Connecting/ mapping ideas	12 (30)	Synthesis of methods	10 (37)	Multiple sources	10 (34)	New findings	4 (44)
	New perspective	11 (16)			Topic choice is unconventional	3 (9)	Synthesis of literatures	12 (30)	New use of old data	7 (26)	Non-canonical data	4 (14)		
	New approach to tired/trendy topic	10 (15)					New application of existing theory	5 (13)	Resolve old question or debate	3 (11)				
	New connections	8 (12)					Reconceptualizing	4 (10)	Innovative for discipline	2 (7)				
	New argument	6 (9)					Unconventional use of theory	2 (5)						
	Innovative for the discipline	6 (9)												
	Total	67 (100)		13 (100)		32 (100)		40 (100)		27 (100)		29 (100)		9 (100)
	Total as % of all types	31		6		15		18		12		13		4

Source: Guetzkow, Lamont, and Mallard (2004).

Table 5.3 Frequency of mentions of generic definitions of originality, by disciplinary cluster

	Humanities		*History*		*Social sciences*		*Total*	
Originality type	*N*	%	*N*	%	*N*	%	*N*	%
Approach	29	33	26	43	12	18	67	31
Data	19	21	6	10	4	6	29	13
Theory	16	18	11	18	13	19	40	18
Topic	13	15	6	10	13	19	32	15
Method	4	4	5	8	18	27	27	12
Outcome	3	3	4	7	2	3	9	4
Understudied area	5	6	3	5	5	7	13	6
All generic types	89	100	61	100	67	100	217	100

Source: Guetzkow, Lamont, and Mallard (2004).
Note: A "mention" occurs when a criterion is used during the interview. Some columns do not sum to 100% due to rounding.

research topic and the significance of the likely impact of research findings—on academia as a whole, on one's discipline, on knowledge—as well as the social and/or political impact of the research. Table 5.4 shows the distribution of panelists' references to these categories as they discussed the proposals during post-deliberation interviews. Significance of impact is mentioned slightly more often than significance of topic. Overall, panelists are more concerned with the project's likely influence on knowledge and on academia than with the social or political impact of the research. But there are differences among the panelists by discipline. Predictably, humanists are most concerned with the intellectual significance of the topic, while historians and social scientists are slightly more concerned with the topic's political and social significance.

As mentioned in Chapter 3, and explained in detail elsewhere, panelists use one or more of four different epistemological styles as they evaluate and discuss proposals.[16] These styles—"constructivist," "comprehensive," "positivist," and "utilitarian"—vary in terms of the

Table 5.4 Number of panelists mentioning significance criteria, by disciplinary cluster

	Humanities		*History*		*Social sciences*		*Total*	
	N	*%*	*N*	*%*	*N*	*%*	*N*	*%*
Significance of topic	16	73	16	80	17	85	49	69
Intellectual	15	68*	10	50	9	31	34	48
Political and social	10	45	13	65	17	59	40	56
Significance of impact	16	73	18	90	24	83	58	82
On academia	8	36	9	45	14	48	31	44
On field	8	36	8	40	6	21	22	31
On knowledge	7	32	12	60	14	48	33	46
Political	5	23	2	10	9	31	16	23
Social	5	23	5	25	13	45	23	32
Total	19	86**	19	95	27	93	65	91

Note: A "mention" occurs when a criterion is used during the interview.

*Percentage of all humanists who use "intellectual significance" as a criterion of evaluation.

** Some panelists referred to more than one type of significance.

methodological approach they privilege (in a nutshell: reductivism versus *verstehen*), and whether they are grounded in "knowledge for knowledge's sake" (privileged in the comprehensive and positivist styles) or "knowledge for the sake of social change" (privileged in the constructivist and utilitarian styles). In Table 5.5, the main styles that panelists referred to during our interviews are delineated and contrasted according to the elements valued and prioritized by each style. As Table 5.6 shows, three-quarters of the panelists favor the comprehensive style, which privileges knowledge for knowledge's sake, in describing how they evaluated proposals. This style predominates in all the competitions but one. Overall, it is used by 86 percent of the humanists, 78 percent of the historians, and 71 percent of the social scientists. Use of the other three styles is as we would expect—far more social scientists favor the positivist style than do either historians or humanists; and considerably more humanists and historians use the constructivist style than do social scientists. What is of most

Table 5.5 Most important epistemological styles, as indicated by panelists' interview responses

Epistemological style	*Positive evaluation*	
	Theoretical style	*Methodological style*
Constructivist	When the proposal presents personal, political, and social elements as relevant to research	When the proposal shows attention to details and to the complexity of the empirical object
Comprehensive	When the proposal emphasizes a substantially informed rationale for research and a theoretically informed agenda	When the proposal shows attention to details and to the complexity of the empirical object
Positivist	When the proposal aims to generalize empirical findings, disprove theories, and solve a theoretical puzzle	When the proposal seeks to test alternative hypotheses using a formal model enclosing the world in a defined set of variables
Utilitarian	When the proposal seeks to generalize findings, disprove theories, and solve puzzles related to "real world" problems	When the proposal seeks to test alternative hypotheses using a formal model with a defined set of variables

interest here is not the detail of these distributions but the variety and range of panel members' understandings of what constitutes significance. How do these various understandings shape the way in which these panelists make distinctions regarding scholarly versus social significance?

In *Of the Standard of Taste*, the philosopher David Hume suggests that the appreciation of beauty is "best construed as an idealized, counterfactual ruling, or as the combined opinion of near-ideal critics," that is, "true judges" and experts.[17] Similarly, judgments about scholarly significance can be made only by those who have great

Table 5.6 Number of panelists using each epistemological style, by disciplinary cluster

Epistemological style	*Humanities N*	*Humanities %*	*History N*	*History %*	*Social sciences N*	*Social sciences %*	*N*	*%*
Constructivist	4	28	4	29	3	14	11	22
Comprehensive	12	86	11	78	15	71	38	78
Positivist	0	0	3	23	11	57	14	29
Utilitarian	0	0	1	4	4	19	5	10
Total	14		14		21		49	

Note: Since each interviewee may use more than one style, columns do not sum to 100 percent.

expertise regarding the current state of knowledge in a particular field and about what remains to be done. As one such expert explains, "I'm much more surefooted in my own field, where . . . I can make silver judgments, or more confident judgments, where . . . I'm intimately familiar with the research topic." Of course, there are often disagreements about how much work is needed on a topic. A political scientist addresses this question: "[A panelist] was saying, 'There's too much work on the welfare state.' Frankly, I think he's wrong that there's a bunch of stuff on the welfare state on the particular country she's looking at. Even if you threw that part away, [the proposal] is at the intersection of the "transitions to democracy" [literature] as well . . . It spoke to two huge, maybe the two biggest literatures, in political science today." Thus, determining scholarly significance can depend on personal taste as well as on expertise. An English scholar confirms this fact as he contrasts his own intellectual inclinations with those of a friend who is a literary critic: "[My friend] thinks cultural currents, trends, intellectual history, that's where the action is. The kind of stuff I do in my last book, where I show how much is going on in simple words or paragraphs, he thinks that's just a kind of self-indulgence, like playing around."

Determining significance is also a question of perspective, of the lenses that one privileges. This too is influenced by personal taste. For many social scientists, "to go beyond the anecdotal," to "generalize," are elements of a shared script of excellence. To wit, an economist estimates significance by "theoretical contribution," defined in terms of generalization. "Fundamental theory should apply [everywhere]," he says. When evaluating the significance of a project, he inquires, "Is [the project asking] a detailed question or is it a question that really covers multiple countries and multiple constituencies in multiple countries? If it's an issue that looks at specific aspects relevant for other countries, I would define it as having a broader relevance." A political scientist, though, is skeptical of generalization and law-like statements, "because you can't do it. And, in fact, most people now understand that they can't do it, but there are things about the discipline that reward it anyway." The alternative to generalization is to demonstrate scholarly significance by discussing the theoretical implications of particular studies (in line with the comprehensive epistemological style). This is the approach valued by a panelist who describes himself as a "micro-level social historian." He explains that "it is possible to do detailed studies and place them in a broader comparative framework that brings out its significance for broader things" (such as identity, globalization, inequality, aesthetics, meaning, race, or gender). This approach contrasts with that of a "narrow proposal" that will not be of interest to other scholars. A political scientist justifies the rejection of a "superb proposal for research on a very narrow period" in French history because there was no "knowledge of potential interest outside the specialization of that particular scholar." In all these examples, panelists express taste preferences that are informed by expertise.

Socially and/or politically significant research usually is equated with producing instrumental knowledge and "giving voice" to underrepresented groups. These approaches correspond to the utilitarian and constructivist epistemological styles. The concern with instrumental knowledge is illustrated by a panelist who, in citing John Maynard Keynes as one of his intellectual heroes, says of Keynes: "He was another one of these people who combined very advanced theoretical and abstract thinking about economics, but would never be drifting off the focus on the real world, from a concern with [what to do] to solve problems of the day." For her part, a political scientist takes policy implications very seriously because "it's the only way that we can justify what we do . . . my bias is towards things that are going to make people's lives better . . . Because I think intellectuals are leeches if they don't do that." She favors research "that has some real meaning in the way that power is distributed, or in terms of the solution of social problems."[18]

Illustrating the concern with "giving voice," a cultural studies scholar explains that significance means "potential social significance, as opposed to more narcissistic or solipsistic activity, or . . . simply a sort of gentleperson's activity . . . Scholarship ought to have more impact than simply personal pleasure of a hobby . . . It's important to consider the work of diasporic peoples, of women as opposed to simply men, of popular and folk idioms in addition to elite music." In the 1960s and 1970s, the "invasion" of French theory and the growing influence of Marxism, feminism, and post-structuralism put the "power-culture link" at the center of the intellectual agenda for many humanistic disciplines.[19] This perspective permeates the evaluative scripts used by many panelists, as illustrated by an English professor who remarks, "I don't think a cultural study even comes close to completion if it doesn't offer some reflection on how this cultural phenomenon intersects with power relations . . . I would think that something's missing if gender wasn't included, if race and/or national identity, or some other factor of that kind, is left out." A historian assesses a project's significance in terms of its urgency and timeliness for our understanding of society. So of studying racism, he says, "If we can understand the dynamics of how this arises and how it is preserved . . . that could be valuable." One Marxist historian of post-colonialism admits that political considerations influence his evaluation of proposals. Inspired by the British Marxist historian E. P. Thompson, this panelist is unsympathetic to "certain types of transnational post-modern bit of stuff that follow a particular line that I don't have much of an instinctive sympathy towards."

Unlike assigning weight to scholarly significance, for some panelists, factoring in social relevance raises many concerns. A South Asian historian says, "I would hate to think that academics and academic excellence [are] purely instrumental," in part because the effects of knowledge are rarely immediate. Similarly, an English scholar advocates knowledge for knowledge's sake and beauty for beauty's sake: "I think that the arts and humanities don't need to be justified on the grounds of social usefulness. It is a capitulation to try to talk about that." Others are critical of an instrumental conception of knowledge because they view it as leading to "subjectivism." Indeed, 45 percent of the respondents mention concern with bias when discussing the evaluation of proposals. Yet others echo Bourdieu's analysis of the functioning of scientific fields when they refuse to subordinate research to what they perceive as neoliberal instrumentalism. They defend the autonomy of academia against logics of action driven by political or economic pursuits.[20]

These tensions surrounding social significance are illustrated by differences in opinion between a geographer and an anthropologist. The geographer explains that he is inspired by issues of inequality: "I love . . . thinking about issues of the subaltern, the disadvantaged, and sort of trying to be a medium of communication in their situation and plight, and to also work with concepts of indigenous knowledge . . . I'm very much politically committed to diversity of lived experience on this planet." But an anthropologist criticizes this panelist as too easily swayed by political considerations: "There were proposals on environmental issues he would read and argue for, even though they were terrible proposals and everybody thought they were terrible proposals. He said, 'Well, this is an important environmental problem.' . . . It could be an important problem, but if you don't know how to study it, you're not going to really help to solve it." Reaffirming the positivist credo, an economist believes good scholarship is incompatible with advocacy: "The definition of an academic is someone who doesn't believe anything until [proven]. That begs the question of what are your hypotheses, what is your default position, which could be subject to all kinds of intrinsic, political, ideological, or just national bias." But a political scientist criticizes what he calls this economist's "pseudo-neutral" position of objectivity. "His politics were different from mine and he was very clear about, you know, 'I don't have a viewpoint. Either the person is biased or unbiased.' But he would pull the [neutrality] card when he was reading proposals by lefties." This political scientist questions whether social significance is an appropriate criterion of evaluation. He says: "I've never seen proposals that are socially useful . . . I don't think it's more significant that someone wants to work on refugee camps in Rwanda . . . [or on] French Maoism, because we really are social scientists who are defining [ourselves] in a particular career path, which is going to be about theory and teaching in universities."

Methods and the proper use of theory. Four of the five funding programs I studied, as well as others, often mention methods as a criterion of interest. Here again, there is a great deal of variation and ambiguity regarding the aspects of methods that are emphasized. For instance, the SSRC program mentions "responsiveness to methodological concerns" and "rationale for field work" as aspects of method that proposals should address. The anonymous social science foundation asks that proposals adopt a methodology appropriate for the goal for the research. Given this variation, I focus here on a specific aspect of methods that is correlated with quality: the articulation of theory and data. This is a topic of concern for roughly half of all respondents, but nearly three-quarters of the social scientists rank it as important (as compared to less than half of the humanists). It also figures prominently in graduate training in the social sciences. A historian of China provides a good description of the importance of the alignment between theory and data when she explains that combining several types of evidence helps produce a solid proposal. Drawing an analogy with crafting a table, she says, "The size of the table and the sturdiness of the table depend on how many legs [it has] and where they're placed . . . The table with one leg that is a broad generalization with one little foundation doesn't work. Four solid foundations, well, that's solid." A political scientist's account of the strongest proposal focuses on the articulation between theory and method: "[The applicant] had a clear sense of how to use a case to address theory. He took us through some of the main theories [of genocide] and showed how the Rwanda case . . . didn't confirm them in any straightforward way. And used that as a basis for establishing both, one, [that this was a] clear puzzle, [a] clear question . . . [and two,] what it was . . . obviously a case of. He inserted a comparative dimension into it in a way that was pretty ingenious, I thought, looking at regional variations."

Panelists wax poetic—evoking a language of beauty and appreciation—in describing proposals that reach perfect articulation between the research question, the theory informing the research, the method proposed, and the evidence mobilized to answer the question. This is where one can see craft at its best. Thus an economist provides this appreciative description of his favorite proposal, written by a political philosopher: "It's very rare that you find someone that can go from the very abstract political philosophy kind of literature and also design a good feasible empirical social science proposal to actually study how [international philanthropic organizations] work." In assessing how applicants achieve this ideal alignment, some panelists are most concerned with the theoretical dimension, echoing the assessment of intellectual significance. But here the issue is typically the presence or absence of a theoretical rationale for case selection. For instance, a political scientist criticizes a proposal on the grounds that "it was very unclear why she picked one place versus another place. The logic didn't seem to have been worked out. Reading her proposal you could see she was trying not very convincingly to respond to those very criticisms that other political scientists would formulate: . . . 'Why should it be a case study if you're pretending to make more generalizable claims?'"

Some more inductively inclined evaluators do not require a tight fit between theory and data because they expect the theoretical contribution to emerge in the process of gathering data. "Some people want a hypothesis before you go in," a sociologist observes, "[and] some people are quite prepared to accept that those hypotheses come out of the work. I thought if [this applicant] went in without it, he would actually probably get something more interesting."[21] An economist expresses the opposite view: "A general argument that people will make in this debate is, 'Well, this is an interesting idea and it's a bit of a fishing trip and this person will sort things out once they get there.' . . . For me, personally, this one was so far wrongheaded at the start that I didn't have faith that the person would straighten it out . . . If you haven't got the tools, you're going to write about something that's cool and interesting, but you're not going to do it in a scholarly way. That's a waste of money."

Panelists' discussions of the proper articulation of theory and data reveal differing perceptions concerning how theory should be handled and how much is too much or too little. This is in part a matter of taste and a response to varying disciplinary sensibilities—to varying intellectual habitus—as illustrated by a historian who describes the appropriate use of theory as follows: "There is a kind of high theory that is [in] and of itself beautiful and elegant when it's done right

. . . I want a sense when I read a proposal that there is a mind selecting theory and working theory and an aesthetic to which a candidate is sort of responding deliberately."

As sociologists Charles Camic and Neil Gross note, theory is another polymorphic term.[22] The meanings given to theory vary widely across the social sciences and the humanities, and within each cluster of disciplines. Among our interviewees, a third of the mentions of theory refer most often to the articulation among theory, data, and method, followed by references to schools and to anti-reductionism, including reflexivity (roughly a fifth of the mentions), and to concepts (one in ten)—the remaining 15 percent are spread across various subtypes. The only noticeable differences in emphasis across disciplinary clusters are that humanists are more concerned with references to schools than are historians and social scientists; and social scientists and historians are more concerned with the articulation between theory and data than are humanists.

The diffusion of theory in the humanities that began in the 1970s (see Chapter 3) significantly affects how panelists from these disciplines factor theory into evaluation. A music scholar, agreeing that in the past decades there has been "an importation as well as an adaptation of theoretical models that in particular came out of literary disciplines . . . a whole panoply of post-structuralist scholars from Foucault to Baudrillard to Bourdieu to God knows who," also pronounces the role of theory in the humanities "extraordinarily important." A historian who mobilizes the term "theory" to refer to self-positioning is less enthusiastic. He describes those who adhere to "traditions of interpretive work as opposed to empirical work" as potentially "more vulnerable" to a "sort of posture or positioning that isn't about theory as tool, but about theory as statement of fidelities to all of the proper figures . . . It's merely a way of . . . saying, 'I'm on this guy's side' and 'I'm this guy's guy.'"

Humanists are particularly concerned with reflexivity, which is opposed to a naivety associated with earlier forms of humanistic scholarship. According to one panelist, reflexivity involves being "self-conscious about the very nature of historical narratives, about one's own practice when one inserts oneself into the telling of history . . . Because these kinds of academic practices are cultural practices, you know, they're not natural, they have their own culture . . . What's involved in being theoretically astute is that this is a form of ongoing self-criticism." To this, he opposes an unsophisticated proposal that he defines as one devoid of theory, that is "just kind of seat-of-the-pants descriptive scholarship . . . it is really unclear what is the guiding principle organizing the study. It's sort of popular chit-chat . . . it struck me as scholarship lite." Thus, for some evaluators, the proper use of theory may play a crucial role in pushing a proposal above the proverbial line of funded projects. What may be seen by humanists as essential positioning and self-reflexivity will be viewed as narcissistic self-indulgence by more positivist social scientists. Unavoidable differences affect outcomes, but as we saw in Chapter 4, the influence of individual tastes is counterbalanced by cognitive contextualization and rules about consistency.

If theory is deemed essential by many, panelists, especially historians, also heavily criticize the abuse of theory. In fact, panelists appear to be more aggravated by this failing than by most others. An English scholar condemns this practice in strong moral terms:

> Clarity trumps elegance, even in the English proposals, because what are we all doing if we're trying to build knowledge and [if] we can't communicate . . . [?] If I feel someone's using the jargon just to throw it around and say "I read Gayatri Spivak," forget it, that dog's not going to hunt with me . . . Now do I want to use a word as strong as dishonesty? It's a kind of trying to parade a supposed sophistication . . . It's also a kind of superficiality or laziness, not wanting to really think through either a theoretical proposition or the application of it . . . I'm not anti-theory at all

> . . . [what] I don't like to see is theory using people . . . scholars should be using the theory.

An anthropologist sees the abuse of theory in the use of convoluted sentences and an overly abstract language that, to her, signals preciousness. About one proposal she particularly disliked, she says, "I also found the writing style just insufferable." In this instance, however, the panel "overlooked the style and went for the content."

Many of the historians interviewed reject the use of theory as a tool for generalization. One evaluator states that she "only likes middle-level generalizations, because that's where you have the possibility of saying something that's actually useful . . . I'm not interested in the connections at the level that will explain three societies at once across all time." For historians, theory is particularly irritating if it is not adequately integrated with the empirical material. A French historian explains that she is not opposed "to theory itself," but she was put off by a particular proposal because it "seemed to kind of tack on theory about the public sphere, and it isn't well integrated . . . I found that it was kind of intellectually pretentious." A similar commitment to a restrained use of theory is clear in the comments of a historian associated with cultural studies. He is irritated by the aura of "hipness" that is associated with theorists, the "kind of originality that consists of somebody trying to ride the sort of leading edge with a lot of buzz words and jargons that's kind of compulsive . . . Somebody like [a certain well-known anthropologist] annoys the hell out of me a lot of the time . . . He would be a good case of somebody who went from useful experiment to compulsive originality, where . . . everything you write has to look fundamentally unlike the last thing that you wrote." Considered together, these quotes suggest that theory, a polymorphic term, can be the source of different types of tensions.

Feasibility. The final formal criterion of evaluation provided to panelists by funding programs is that of feasibility, which refers to both the scope of the project (including its timeline, plan of work, and budget) and the preparedness of the applicant (including language skills, past experience, and advisers). Half the panelists mention factoring in feasibility when making an evaluation, and it is of roughly equal concern for historians, humanists, and social scientists. As a political scientist explains, evaluators typically ask, "[Is it] the right proposal being done by the right person? Oftentimes you see really great proposals and you think it should be being done by somebody else." Another panelist observes, "We're wasting our money and they're wasting our time if they can't do what they think they're doing." She assesses feasibility based on whether "they have a concept that can be examined, given the human limitations of the student, the people that they're looking at, or the evidence that they're looking at." Summarizing the importance of the plan of work, a political scientist says, "People can't know all the answers, but at least [they should] have a sense of where they're going to go when they get in the car. They should have [a] road map. Obviously they can make mistakes, but they should at least be in the right country." The track-record aspect of feasibility is important because all academics recognize how difficult it is to remain productive, given the many demands that accrue with seniority (many panelists themselves describe being less productive than they would like to be). Nevertheless, as noted earlier, factoring in an applicant's track record can cause problems because panel members may disagree about its proper weight. Some see past level of activity as correlated with excellence, and indeed, some empirical research supports this claim; others feel it can be misleading.[23]

Informal, "Evanescent" Criteria of Evaluation

In addition to applying the formal criteria prescribed by the funding agency, panelists use other, unofficially acknowledged criteria as part of the evaluation process. They are not necessarily always aware that they are doing so, however. As an English professor notes, "intuition and flair" play important roles in judging excellence, as does "just having a sort of eye for it." In many cases, these more evanescent criteria—the presence of "elegance," the ability to generate "excitement," a display of cultural capital—all combine to create a sense that an applicant is (or has) the "it" that everyone is looking for. Such considerations influence the signaling process as well as collective definitions of what is "hot." A historian, chair of a panel, recognizes the influence of such evanescent qualities. Rather than viewing their use as idiosyncratic or capricious, and thus as incompatible with making fair decisions, he sees panelists' application of evanescent criteria as an essential part of identifying true excellence:

> There are these intuitive aspects to it, and at the same time, I believe we're doing social science. These aspects have aesthetic sides to them, like "This is a very elegant or striking proposal." This is an important part of the individual and group processes. That doesn't mean that . . . we don't have standards. I think that those two things can go together quite well, especially if you're looking for things that are just a little bit outside the norm. You're actually looking for some of those qualities in the spark, the godlike qualities in the proposal.

These informal criteria appear to be used equally by panelists across the three disciplinary clusters. Even scholars from disciplines that view subjectivity as corrupting and as a source of bias (such as economists) show no special reluctance to judge who has "it" and who does not. Similarly, humanists are not less likely to factor in moral considerations. Instead, all panelists reference these informal criteria throughout their accounts of the deliberations. And recourse to these criteria does not appear to be limited only to times when reliance on formal standards has resulted in deadlocks. Panel members seem to appeal to evanescent criteria as the inspiration strikes. This is probably because such considerations permeate academic life, motivating scholars as they go about doing research and interacting with colleagues. Who is smart and less smart, who has a sense of analytical elegance and flair, who is boring or pedestrian, who is a mensch and who is not to be trusted—such preoccupations are routine for academics. Thus it is hardly surprising that panelists factor in these concerns when they find themselves locked in a room for a few hours, or a few days, and asked to make judgments on their peers. Far from corrupting the process of identifying and rewarding excellence, I see these considerations as intrinsic to it. In any case, they are unavoidable.

Divining signs of intelligence. As Table 5.7 shows, three-quarters of the respondents mention at least one dimension of "signs of intelligence" in discussing their assessment of proposals. An applicant's intelligence, according to an English professor, can be seen in the "subtlety and complexity with which the project is framed." For this panelist, intelligence is an "ability to understand and present complex ideas in an orderly fashion, to balance potentially conflicting positions or information and present that kind of complication clearly." The importance that evaluators attach to signs of intelligence is further indicated by the descriptions they provide of their intellectual heroes, who tend to be scholars who excel at making sense of complex phenomena. For example, a political scientist who singled out the political sociologist Seymour Martin Lipset emphasizes the complexity of Lipset's thought: "He's a primitive genius. He's able to pick up an enormously complex literature and he's able to take an angle on it that somehow captures some essential elements of those questions in the literature . . . He can kind of figure out what is going on. He can smell it." Similarly, a historian describes Robert Palmer's book *The Age of the Democratic Revolution* as impressive for "its abil-

Table 5.7 Number of panelists mentioning informal criteria, by disciplinary cluster

	Humanities		*History*		*Social sciences*		*Total*	
Criterion	*N*	*%*	*N*	*%*	*N*	*%*	*N*	*%*
Signs of intelligence (all)	18	82	15	75	20	69	53	75
Articulate	7	32	8	40	5	17	20	28
Competent	12	54	10	50	16	55	38	53
Intelligent	13	59	6	30	11	38	30	42
Talented	4	18	0	0	7	24	11	15
Elegance and cultural capital	16	73	14	70	16	55	46	65
Cultural ease	13	59	9	45	10	34	32	45
Cultural breath	8	36	8	40	10	34	26	36
Personal qualities								
Interesting	17	77	9	45	22	76	48	67
Exciting	7	32	4	20	7	24	18	25
Boring	3	13	3	15	7	24	13	18
Moral qualities (all)	8	40	9	46	11	37	29	41
Determination	8	41	4	20	9	31	22	31
Humility	7	32	4	20	4	14	15	21
Authenticity	6	27	2	10	6	21	14	19

Note: A "mention" occurs when a criterion is used during the interview.

ity to treat the distinctiveness of particular cases, yet discern a larger transformation that transcended those particular areas, [seeing] a larger story within all of those smaller stories."

Conversations with members of the Society of Fellows, the most elite of the five funding organizations, and the only one to conduct interviews with finalists, offer a look at what counts as intelligence in a highly rarefied stratum of the academic world (in this competition, applicants' odds of being awarded a fellowship are less than one in two hundred). These respondents tend to see intellectual refinement as a mixture of various traits held in delicate balance. An English professor, for example, describes the top candidate thus: "This person is extremely impressive and articulate, but in a way that actually establishes a circuit of exchange rather than everybody says one smart thing to sort of [lead] the discussion . . . So I take this as a sign that he is really listening. He [is] extremely successful in the way he describes [his work] and extremely interesting. But it has to do with a kind of nimbleness of his own mind and his questions and answers." The classification system used to assess intelligence in this setting appears to allow for finer gradations and nuances. As we will see, moral factors combine with intellectual factors to define who is considered a truly meritorious intellectual.

Elegance and cultural capital. Who better epitomized the virtues of scholarly elegance than the anthropologist Clifford Geertz? His classic essay on the Balinese cockfight is often singled out as a particularly felicitous illustration of elegance in the interpretative social sciences.[24] For several respondents, it also illustrates a particular script for evaluating excellence. An anthropologist, after explaining that all the proposals she ranked highly were well written, refers to the cockfight article as "a model of what it is that we do best when we're doing what we should do." She defines her own understanding of academic excellence as oriented toward a "kind of perfectionism, trying to get the language right." Elegance also is often associated with the display of cultural capital—that is, it is linked to the ability to demonstrate familiarity with such high-status signals as cultural literacy.[25] For instance, a French historian says that she appreciates good writing, which she defines as the ability to express oneself with "some literacy." Nearly two-thirds of all respondents mention elegance and display of cultural capital when describing the evaluation of proposals and applicants (see Table 5.7). There are differences across disciplinary clusters. Humanists and historians particularly value elegance and cultural capital, and social scientists give it less emphasis.[26] About elegance a philosopher says, "I think it's wonderful. Elegance means clear, not rococo prose, though rococo prose can be elegant. It means not trying to sound like a social scientist," which would be "an effort to submerge the individual style altogether. I want to have a strong personal voice."[27] With respect to cultural capital, panel members are particularly concerned with cultural breadth and cultural ease.

It is often difficult to disentangle elegance from the display of a cultural capital that is very unevenly distributed across disciplines, as well as across types of academic institutions and across the class structure. In *Homo Academicus,* Bourdieu describes not only the humanities as carrying considerable cultural capital, but also traditional elite universities and the culture of the "dominant class" (the upper middle class).[28] Valuing elegance and the display of cultural capital may mean conflating excellence with elite or upper-middle-class membership.[29] When this occurs, Bourdieu would suggest, panelists penalize applicants from working-class backgrounds, who routinely suffer from class-based discrimination.[30] In a Bourdieuian logic, the applicants who are construed as most brilliant are also those who have the greatest familiarity and ease with the academic world (for instance, those who are offspring of academics). Students of working-class origins operating in elite academic environments often feel stigmatized, experience ambivalence toward their past, and learn to conceal their backgrounds. This is likely to influence their degree of ease—which in turn is likely to be associated with their degree of demonstrated elegance and poise, and thus also with the likelihood of being defined as doing "exciting" and "interesting" work (on this topic see also Chapter 6).[31]

Valuing what is "exciting" and "interesting." Positive perceptions of work as "exciting" and "interesting" cannot be bracketed out of the evaluation process. But what exactly do these terms mean? In his article "That's Interesting: Toward a Phenomenology of Sociology and a Sociology of Phenomenology," Murray Davis examines a large number of sociological contributions deemed "interesting" and concludes that "interesting theories deny certain assumptions of their audience, while non-interesting theories affirm certain assumptions."[32] An anthropologist's description of a good proposal as one "that seems intrinsically interesting to me" states: "I want the writer to be able to convey that this is a project they're interested in . . . It's a sense that it's something important, because if it's not important enough to excite them, then why should they get funding?" "Boring," the opposite of "exciting," is equated with repetition (a historian observes, "if a person has had some success at a certain kind of analysis, [she should not] keep doing more of it"). But boringness can also have a more damning connotation. One of the most antagonistic exchanges reported during the post-deliberation interviews with panelists involved a historian who told a political scientist that proposals from that field were "not so much difficult to evaluate, but just extremely, well, boring, and sort of filled with jargon. [They were] just sort of artificially constructed . . . around these kind of criteria that were intrinsically uninteresting." Panel members' preferences for "exciting" work may indirectly advantage applicants (and their recommenders) from elite universities, to the extent that these individuals are better positioned to tap widely shared understandings of what is "cutting-edge," "exciting," or "boring" at any point in time. This possibility suggests one way in which informal criteria may work against meritocratic evaluation.

In Chapter 4, we saw that panelists often use idiosyncratic standards of evaluation (an ex-tennis star was drawn to a proposal on the body, a fan of modern dance to a study of dance, a bird enthusiast to work on songbirds), but there are also important variations in how panelists believe subjectivity—their own view of what is exciting versus boring—affects the evaluation. As Table 5.7 shows, humanists cite work as "interesting" or "exciting" slightly more often than do historians and social scientists. Humanists and more interpretative social scientists (anthropologists and cultural historians) may be more at ease with the role played by their subjectivity in evaluation.[33] After all, their interpretative power is their main analytical tool. In addition, their expertise, being more purely interpretative in character, does not employ technical black-boxing tools of the types that Bruno Latour describes in *Science in Action* and *The Pasteurization of France.*[34] The production of social science knowledge, in contrast, relies on specific data-collection techniques (surveys, interviews, observation) and tools for data analysis (qualitative content-analysis software or statistical analysis packages) to settle controversies.[35] Competition between opposite views of what "excites" and "interests" thus are perhaps more intense in the humanistic fields.

Panelists in noninterpretative disciplines, however, sometimes are extremely critical of using "what is interesting" or "cool" as a criterion of evaluation. Suspicious of idiosyncratic tastes, these panelists try to balance an appreciation of the researcher's ability with the project's intrinsic interest. A historian, for example, wants to couple appreciation of interest with an evaluation of competence: "Heavily quantitative proposals with a lot of arcane equations and things like that in it would have a hard time sparking my interest. I try to overcome that and make sure it's not just a matter of taste and try to understand what it is really that's being tested and what the chance of a significant result will be here, even if it's not my taste." A sociologist explicitly subordinates interest to competence. Referring to my own area of expertise, cultural sociology, he says: "If there [are] some really fine projects that come along looking for funding you would just get extremely excited about it at the level of intrinsic interests. But I might just say, 'Well you know, here's another culture project,' whatever. But why should I stand in the way of a really excellent project because it doesn't get my blood boiling?"

Moral Qualities of the Applicant

The vernacular of excellence that panelists use is laced with references to the moral character of applicants. As my colleagues and I have argued elsewhere, these references to moral character—particularly to "courageous risk-takers" and to "lazy conformists"—contradict the literature on peer review, which frames extra-intellectual consideration as corrupting the evaluation process.[36] Again, this literature ignores the extent to which self-concept shapes the way panelists appreciate and evaluate the work of others. Among the panelists, an English professor notes this influence, remarking that "the older I get, I've realized more and more how my own intellectual preoccupations really do spring from concerns that I just meet in my everyday life, and the kind of everyday major decisions I've had to make in the course of my own personal life and in my career." As we have seen in previous chapters (especially Chapter 4), scholarship is far from being an abstract and disconnected pursuit; instead, it is intimately tied to the image that academics hold of themselves (including their relative status), and to how they think they should lead their lives.

Table 5.7 shows that 41 percent of panelists refer to applicants' moral qualities when assessing proposals—enough to support the conclusion that doing so is not exceptional, but part of the normal order of things. Panelists privilege determination and hard work, humility, authenticity, and audacity. They express how the management of the self—the display of a proper scholarly and moral habitus—is crucial to definitions of excellence across fields. These qualities suggest that at least some panelists select not only scholars, but also human beings whom they deem worthy of admiration for moral reasons. Thus a political scientist says he recognizes excellence "first of all, by the willingness of someone to stick their neck out seriously to propose to produce disconfirmable knowledge"; and a historian praises "the person who is in control of their own intellectual work, who sort of has made their own choices, who has reasons for doing everything they're doing. That to me always stands out and it always distinguishes the very best people." Some of the specific moral qualities most frequently mentioned by panelists are discussed below (and shown in Table 5.7).

Determination is associated with one's ability to overcome hardship, and with a strong work ethic. Of his best student, a distinguished philosopher says, "The trajectory and the sheer will . . . and good will with which she did all this, I really admire that immensely . . . the fact that she overcame what I felt were actual weaknesses [which] were strengths that neither she nor I, nor anyone else had seen at the time, and that she ended up finding that there was a lot of talent and ability there."

Humility or unpretentiousness is viewed as an added measure of excellence, especially when coupled with superlative expertise. This is expressed by a panelist who describes a winner of the ultra-selective Society of Fellows competition: "Without seeming like an old pedant, he seemed to have the control of his area that only somebody who's worked for thirty years has. And without being either overbearing or patronizing or boring, he just communicated an immense amount of information, all of it articulate and structured at the same time." An anthropologist who served as a panelist for a different competition recalls an applicant who received funding despite an overbearing self-presentation. The panelist had disliked the "relentlessly self-promoting, arrogant tone of the proposal," which he equated with the applicant's personal characteristics:

> What troubled me was the performance aspect of it. He was going to prove that everyone was wrong about their interpretation of this [historical event], and he was going to make this, his idea of truth, into the general[ly] accepted one . . . But I could take the point, and it was certainly a brilliant piece of work, aside from his own recognition of his own brilliance . . . As much as I hate to give anything to this guy, he deserves it, and that's fine.

A geographer also stresses morality when he describes his intellectual hero: "Peter Wood . . . [is] a model person, very modest. I think there's too much arrogance in academia . . . I always find restraint and modesty marvelous qualities in a first-rate scholar."

Authenticity, which often goes hand in hand with audacity, is also singled out as a valued trait. Panelists appreciate applicants who are true to themselves, even if that means pursuing less popular paths. For instance, a sociologist says of his favorite applicant, "I appreciated her willingness to take on a very risky project, but [one] that potentially had a huge payoff in terms of reshaping or fundamentally challenging the received view on Japanese politics, and hence on comparative politics about advanced industrial societies." He compares her to those who succumb to the pressures to reproduce the work of their advisers and are slaves to "what is hot." A well-known and highly regarded historian speaks regretfully of the "very clear vision of career" that he sees as animating "the current generation." Similarly, referring to the "sterility of professionalization," an English professor explains:

> Students very much begin to pick up early in their career how they have to signal to different interest groups that they are of their persuasion . . . The students that I've been most excited about and whose work I learn the most from are those who really are passionately attached to an author, to a subject, to a problem. And it shows, it shows in their writing, it shows in how ultimately fearless they are in pursuing a track . . . So when I'm on panels, those are [some] of the things I immediately [look for] . . . sort of originality and a distinct sense of engagement. [Others] make me feel that I'm kind of in an echo chamber, that there's no original sound that I feel that I've experienced.

Authenticity is especially central in the accounts of the Society of Fellows panelists. One philosopher, pointing to the sincerity of a winner's intellectual engagement, notes that this applicant had "a kind of complete absorption in his topic, and yet, an ability to communicate that absorption . . . You felt that there's a real love for the work and that he has good ideas about it and that he knows a damn lot about it." The same esteemed historian quoted earlier, who was also a member of this panel, describes one of the top candidates as having great passion for his work, as well as great intellectual honesty and integrity. "It was clear that he was someone who had attracted extraordinary attention . . . But what really was remarkable [was the] sense that this is a young man who works on a rarefied topic, but he was somebody you'd love to talk to." Of a third candidate, he says:

> What we found in talking to him was that there was a real kind of depth and interest in what he said, a real passion, which was very impressive . . . [He had] incredible intellectual commitment, which had driven him in really a very short time to be an extraordinary Slavic expert . . . [He had] a kind of non-career-oriented fanatical energy.

When I asked this historian "To what extent do you feel that you are rewarding a moral self or a different intellectual identity?" he responded, "We're unquestionably doing that. Unquestionably. A substantial part of the way the committee works is by its response to the person, and what you very nicely call the 'moral self.' That is, these are not quantifiable reactions. These are not reactions that you could necessarily document. But there's no question."

Conclusion

This chapter explored the many meanings given to excellence by panelists, as well as the relative salience of formal and informal criteria of evaluation. Here I focused on differences between disciplinary clusters—the humanities, the social sciences, and history—as opposed to differences between and within individual disciplines (the focus of Chapter 3). At the level of disciplinary cluster, such differences seem much less accentuated. This may be because differences get washed out when considered in the aggregate, or because there are cross-cutting differences that make overall patterns less easily discernable.

We saw that among the respondents, significance and originality stand out as the most important of the formal criteria used, followed at a distance by clarity and methods. Informal standards are also a factor in evaluation and play a significant enough role to be considered part of the normal order of things. This is particularly the case for cultural capital and morality, two considerations that are extraneous to merit per se. The panelists admire intellectual virtuosos, risk-takers who offer a counterpoint to the duller, more staid image of the scholar that prevails in the American collective imagination. They praise applicants with "deft" and "elegant" minds—traits that are sometimes read through class signals or evidence of cultural capital. Panelists are enamored by those who are able to do intellectual somersaults, in part by creating repeated challenges throughout their careers, even after they have been able to build fairly comfortable positions for themselves.

Panelists' self-identity figures significantly in the evaluation process. While some panelists appreciate the role of subjectivity in the production and evaluation of knowledge, others try to bracket it out because they view it as a corrupting force. Also, some panelists are eager to reward scholars who demonstrate specific moral traits. These traits, which are considered separately from the content of their bearers' proposals, appear to be tied directly to the evaluators' idealized view of what makes academic life a worthy pursuit—the determination, humility, and authenticity that reveal a real depth of commitment to one's vocation.

By analyzing the specific meanings that panelists assign to evaluation criteria, I have also demonstrated here that in the vast and multifaceted universe of academic evaluation, criteria such as "originality" or "quality" are defined in a great many ways. One normative conclusion to be drawn from this observation is that it is pointless to attempt to collapse the many considerations that factor into funding decisions into a single matrix, whether it be grounded in positivist or in interpretive epistemologies. Academia is a highly variegated world, one where qualitatively incommensurate proposals cannot be subsumed under a single standard. Methodological rigor is defined somewhat differently whether one wishes to produce theoretical generalizations, or demonstrate what specific cases tell us about broader social processes. Similarly, significance can be measured in social or in intellectual or theoretical terms. Each and all of these standpoints enrich our understanding of what makes research a meaningful endeavor—and, likewise, shape the value we assign to the work of others.

Finally, we saw that evaluators' personal tastes and areas of expertise—as seen, for instance, in their preferences for more or less theory and more or less emphasis on social and intellectual significance—are interlaced in ways that the experts themselves do not always acknowledge. Such preferences appear to be unavoidable, and the technology of deliberation that is at the center of grant peer review is not fitted with mechanisms for countering idiosyncrasies or even capriciousness. The influence of such variables stands in sharp contrast to the view that "cream rises," that cognitive contextualism always applies, or that criteria are consistent.

Academic evaluation is fraught with imperfections, despite the strongest commitment to customary rules of evaluation. As we have seen here and in Chapter 4, the meanings and weight given to a variety of formal and informal criteria of evaluation constrain and orient the process, but ultimately, reasoned judgments are buffeted by unpredictable human proclivities, agency, and improvisation. These countervailing forces define the coexisting strengths and weaknesses of grant peer review as it is practiced in American higher education. Even if one were able to erase all particularistic considerations from the evaluation process, there would still be culturally and socially embedded assessments. The goal of a consistent and unified process is utopian: perspectives shift and the weight given to each criterion varies as the characteristics of the group of proposals being considered prime evaluators to consider different facets of each proposal in turn. How will these idiosyncrasies of the grant-review process accommodate considerations of interdisciplinarity and diversity?